SWORD v17c Release Notes

Version: v17c (build 0.0.15) **Date:** November 2026 (data exported 1 November 2026); first v17c release July 2026
Base version: SWORD v17b (March 2025, UNC)

Changelog

Published on Zenodo (concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.3898569): build 0.0.12 on 17 July 2026; the same data again on 2 September 2026 with the v17b-to-v16 ID translation archive added to the record; and build 0.0.15 in November 2026. Builds 0.0.13 and 0.0.14 were shared with collaborators for evaluation and were not published.

0.0.15 (November 2026)

- **`facc` partitioned conservatively at channel splits.** At every one of the 2,893 reaches with more than one downstream channel, the area given to a side channel is now debited from the main channel, including distributaries that never rejoin. Before the fix, 903 of the 2,893 splits handed out more than 1 km^2 beyond the parent reach's area; the shares now close at all 2,893 (largest residual 9e-10 km^2). Relative to 0.0.14, `facc` changed on 19,150 reaches and 897,758 nodes: 2,412 reaches raised (median +6%) and 16,738 lowered (median -9%).
- **`facc_total` carried unsplit through rejoins.** The whole-river area no longer drops where a branch reconnects to another channel. The 314 downstream drops found by an 18,241-junction test are now 0. `facc_total` changed on 2,114 reaches and 79,852 nodes. Agreement with reference drainage areas is unchanged to within six comparisons (see §2.3).
- **`facc_flag` and `facc_quality` reassessed from the current values.** Every reach was re-labelled from fresh source and topology calculations in all 60 basins; nodes copy their reach. 9,513 reach flags changed. All 1,428 junctions where outgoing `facc` is below the sum of its inflows now carry a non-`ok` flag (1,421 `suspect`, 7 `same_river`). `facc_quality` is now `rederived_v3:<source>` (NetCDF codes 3001-3008) and records the source method only; it is not an accuracy grade. The variable keeps the name and int32 type of the July 2026 release, where code 1 meant "corrected by the denoise"; the code spaces do not overlap, so a July value cannot be misread as a 0.0.15 one, but the meaning has changed.
- **Two reaches' scalar neighbour columns corrected** (AS 45220300256, NA 71382000696). A downstream neighbour stored in `rch_id_up_1` moved to `rch_id_dn_1` in the GeoPackage, GeoParquet and DuckDB columns. The NetCDF `rch_id_up`/`rch_id_dn` arrays already had the right connections.
- **Exports regenerated in all six formats** from one database state and checked against it field by field (the four facc fields on every reach and node in every format). Apart from the four facc fields and the two reaches above, every value is identical to the 0.0.14 NetCDF, GeoPackage and GeoParquet files; the Shapefile, DuckDB and global files, absent from 0.0.14, were built from the same database state.

0.0.14 (October 2026)

- **`facc` rebuilt from MERIT-Basins.** SWORD reaches were matched to the MERIT-Basins river network and its drainage areas copied onto them, replacing the 0.0.12 denoise of MERIT Hydro D8 values. Along a single channel `facc` never decreases downstream, and in an 18,241-junction test every junction exit is at least its largest inflow.
- **`facc_total` added** (reaches and nodes, km^2): the whole river's drainage area at that point, all channels combined. It equals `facc` except in braided and delta reaches.
- **`facc_flag` added** (reaches and nodes): one label per reach (`ok`, `same_river`, `braid_share`, `delta_arm`, `filled`, `suspect`).
- **Accuracy against reference areas** (share within 20%, on `facc_total`): HydroBASINS outlets 84.8% (v17b 72.7%), SVS gauges 92.4% (v17b 77.6%), USGS gauges 97.0% (v17b 76.2%).

0.0.13 (October 2026)

- **`facc` rederived on all nodes and reaches** from MERIT Hydro sections matched to SWORD (`facc_quality = rederived_v1:<source>:<tier>`). The v17b values 0.0.12 kept on uncorrected reaches left the product. Superseded by the MERIT-Basins matching in 0.0.14.

0.0.12 (built May 2026, published July 2026)

- **Node coordinates restored to v17b for SWOT D0-D2 continuity.** The 344 reaches whose nodes were rederived in 0.0.8 and 0.0.10 now use v17b node `x`/`y`, `node_length`, `cl_id_min`, and `cl_id_max` values again. A small OC split-revert residue on reach 51111300061 was included in the same pass. Post-revert validation found zero node coordinate differences relative to v17b NetCDF across all 11,112,454 nodes.
- **Centerline-to-node assignments resynchronized.** `centerlines.node_id` was restored from v17b on affected reaches so node geometry and centerline allocation remain internally consistent.
- **Node order repaired on restored-coordinate reaches.** Projection-based ordering over the v17b-restored node coordinates updates `node_order` on 3,725 nodes across 221 of the 344 affected reaches, and updates 45 `dn_node_id`/`up_node_id` boundary pairs. The repair preserves node coordinates and recomputes the six node distance fields from the current midpoint convention across all 344 restored-coordinate reaches, including a distance-only cleanup for 289 inherited `dist_out` rows on five unchanged-order reaches. AS reach 35301100891 now encodes POM's intended downstream-to-upstream sequence (`2, 3, ..., 23, 25, 26, 24, 27, ..., 73, 75, 74, 1`) without moving node lat/lon.
- **SWOT slope observations recomputed from node WSE.** `slope_obs_*` on reaches now comes from pass-level regressions of RiverSP node `wse_sm` against the current beta12 `nodes.dist_out`, then reach-level percentiles of those pass slopes. This replaces stale reach-level signed RiverSP slopes whose sign could reflect older node ordering. Median `slope_obs_p50` coverage is 173,732 reaches; negative medians decrease from 18,805 before the correction to 9,988 after the correction. POM's canonical AS reach 35301100891 changes from `slope_obs_p50=-0.0136548684` to `+0.0142687580` m/m while retaining `slope=15.121399` m/km. Downstream users should read both `slope` and `slope_obs_*` directly from 0.0.12; no external sign flip is needed for reaches whose node order changed. The 221 operation-999 `node_order` repair reaches are all in first-digit POM regions 1-6. Test 16 slope-observation and endpoint-WSE diagnostics in first-digit regions 7-9 are separate warning populations, not additional 0.0.12 node-order repairs.
- **Static MERIT/SRTM slope semantics unchanged.** The legacy `reaches/slope` variable remains the nonnegative MERIT/SRTM slope magnitude in m/km; it is not a signed flow-direction variable. 0.0.12 does not change `reaches/slope`, `reaches/wse`, or `nodes/wse` relative to v17b. Endpoint-WSE sign checks may still warn where inherited MERIT/SRTM node WSE values are locally inconsistent with flow direction; those warnings are data-quality diagnostics, not instructions to flip `reaches/slope` or `slope_obs_*`. MERIT/SRTM WSE resampling was evaluated after POM's Test 16 feedback and deferred: the legacy SWORD workflow used UPA-filtered nearest MERIT river pixels and centerline aggregation, so a faithful correction is a science-data reconstruction task rather than a final beta patch.
- **v17c analytic fields preserved.** The revert does not undo the v17c midpoint node-distance convention, lakeflag/type reconciliation, SWOT WSE/width observation statistics, metadata restoration, or export ordering changes. No RiverObs software change or coordinate-substitution mapping table is required for D0-D2 coordinate continuity.
- **Exports regenerated and verified.** NetCDF, GeoPackage, and GeoParquet artifacts were regenerated for all six regions. Export row counts match the DuckDB source for reaches and nodes in GeoPackage/GeoParquet, and for reaches, nodes, and centerlines in NetCDF.

0.0.11 (April 2026)

- **Node ordering normalized in NetCDF export.** About 7.5% of reaches (18,553 globally) had nodes stored in descending dist_out order in all previous SWORD versions due to arbitrary GRWL centerline digitization direction. Nodes are now exported in ascending node_order (downstream-first) for all reaches. This fixes slope sign reversals in processing code that assumes the first node in the array is the downstream end. The underlying data is unchanged; only the file ordering is corrected. This is an export storage-order fix, not a retained topology reversal and not the smaller 0.0.12 operation-999 `node_order` repair set.
- **Restored metadata variables in NetCDF export.** river_name_local, river_name_en, version, add_flag, and swot_obs_source were accidentally omitted from the export spec in 0.0.4. Restored in 0.0.11 on both reaches and nodes where applicable.
- **Node lakeflag propagated from reach.** Node lakeflag now matches parent reach lakeflag across all 11,112,454 nodes, per JPL request.

0.0.10 (April 2026)

- **Node geolocation fixed on 303 additional reaches.** `rederive_nodes` recomputes node x/y from centerline spatial partitioning for reaches where consecutive node gaps exceed 3x the reach's median spacing and 0.4 km

absolute (POM test 6b criteria). By region: AS:189, SA:38, AF:29, EU:21, OC:19, NA:7. Combined with the 41 reaches fixed in 0.0.8, total rederived: 344 reaches (0.14%). **10 reaches were fixed but still trigger the scrambled-node detector** (centerline geometry issues inherited from v17b); see Known Limitations.

- **Reach 35301100891 node_order rotation and geolocation fixed.** This AS reach had node_ids rotated by one position (2, 3, ..., 75, 1 instead of 1, 2, ..., 75) since v17b. Additionally, 74 of 75 nodes were rederived from the centerline (max shift ~12.6 km on node 35301100890011) due to scrambled geolocation detected by POM test 6b. `node_order` now matches `node_id` ascending, `dn_node_id` = 0011, `up_node_id` = 0751. Node dist_out and all interpolated distance columns recalculated to match the corrected node_order.
- **Reach lakeflag and type reconciled for lake classification.** About 6,200 reaches had inconsistent lakeflag and type fields (lakeflag=1 with type=1, or lakeflag=0 with type=3). Inconsistent reaches were either orphaned (skipped by both river and lake processing) or double-counted. Resolution combined three methods: 1,015 manual reviews through the Streamlit QA app, a gradient-boosted classifier trained on those reviews (82% precision, 6% FPR, applied at high confidence only: p>0.8 for lake, p<0.2 for river), and direct corrections from HarP v1.1 lake classifications. Lakeflag and type are now 100% consistent across all 248,673 reaches. The type column now diverges from the reach ID last digit on 2,316 reaches (0.9%) as of 0.0.10 (2,648 by 0.0.12 after subsequent type corrections); the type column is authoritative.
- **Six reaches fixed for N013 closure-bug damage.** Reaches 14278900061 (AF), 31241401301, 48294000081, 45570000125, 34100005185, 42211000503 (AS) had corrupted x/y and cl_id_min/cl_id_max from the N013 closure bug (documented in 0.0.8). Nodes rederived from their own centerlines using the fixed code; node_length restored from v17b NetCDF to preserve exact sum-equals-reach_length consistency. Full sweep confirms zero reaches with node_length mismatch above 0.1% globally.
- **SWOT reach filters aligned with node filters.** `build_reach_filter_sql` now includes cross-track distance (10-60 km) and valid time_str filters, matching the node-level filters. Code change only; no DB data affected.
- **`rederive_scrambled_nodes.py` safeguards added.** After rederiving nodes, the script now automatically recalculates node dist_out (prevents N004 violations) and verifies node_length sums (catches G002 regressions).

0.0.9 (April 2026)

- **Flow correction fully reverted.** All 810 flow-corrected reaches restored to v17b topology after discovering a scoring tautology in `score_section_confidence` (`slope_from_upstream = -slope_from_downstream`). Topology diff vs v17b: 0. `v17c_flow_corrections` table is empty.
- **dist_out corruption fixed.** 1,976 reaches had BFS-corrupted `dist_out` from a January `CALCULATE_DIST_OUT` bug (wrong outlet, 93–99% error). Restored v17b values. T017 violations: 701 → 557.
- **Pipeline re-run with `skip_flow_correction=True`.** All 6 regions pass all gates.

0.0.8 (April 2026)

- **Node `dist_out` unified to midpoint convention.** All six node-level distance columns (`dist_out`, `hydro_dist_out`, `dist_out_dijkstra`, `hydro_dist_hw`, `pathlen_hw`, `pathlen_out`) now use midpoint interpolation from reach-level values. Previously `dist_out` preserved v17b endpoint values while the other five used midpoint, causing a systematic ~100 m discrepancy on single-path networks. On such networks the three outlet-distance columns are now exactly equal at every node. Breaking change from v17b convention; all POM release gate checks pass.
- **Node geolocation fixed on 41 reaches.** `rederive_nodes` recomputes node x/y from centerline spatial partitioning for 41 reaches (SA:5, EU:5, AF:8, AS:20, OC:3) where source NetCDF had contradictory CL-to-node mappings causing >2 km geographic jumps between consecutive nodes. Node lengths now use boundary-to-boundary distances (sum equals `reach_length` exactly). POM example reach 13341000591: max consecutive node jump drops from 13.9 km to 223 m.
- **`rederive_nodes` closure bug fixed.** The N013 centerline sync inside `rederive_nodes` captured a stale `reach_id` from an outer loop instead of the current plan's reach. Fixed to use `plan["reach_id"]`.

0.0.7 (April 2026)

- **Flow-corrected reach node_order and dist_out restored.** When pipeline runs skip the facc stage (e.g. when only rerunning distance and mainstem computations), `flipped_reach_ids` was empty, so `update_node_columns` never reversed `node_order` or swapped `dn_node_id`/`up_node_id` for the 810 flow-corrected reaches. `0.0.6` shipped with `node_order` matching v17b `node_id` order on those reaches (Pierre-Olivier Malaterre detected 389 inverted reaches). `0.0.7` loads the flipped reach IDs from the `v17c_flow_corrections` table when facc is skipped, so the node-order reversal and `dn_node_id`/`up_node_id` swap always run.

- **Node dist_out recomputed for flow-corrected reaches.** After reversing node_order, v17b node dist_out values are stale on 810 reaches (computed from the wrong flow direction). 0.0.7 recomputes them using cumulative node_length midpoint offsets from the corrected downstream boundary, so dist_out is monotonic with node_order and matches the new flow direction.
- **New lint check N018.** Catches the regression above automatically: flags flow-corrected reaches whose node_order is not reversed from v17b node_id order. ERROR severity, wired into the POM release gate.

0.0.6 (April 2026)

- **Canonical export ordering restored.** The 0.0.5 flat-file exports were written in DuckDB storage order through the generic maintenance exporter, which does not preserve a stable logical row order unless it is told to do so. As a result, node arrays in the distributed files could be split across multiple blocks for the same reach even though the per-row attributes stayed aligned.
- **Nodes now export in reach-contiguous logical order.** 0.0.6 writes nodes ordered by reach_id, then node_order, then node_id across NetCDF, GeoPackage, and Parquet. This restores a clean in-file node sequence for downstream consumers that expect each reach to occupy one contiguous node block and to run from downstream (node_order=1) to upstream (node_order=n).
- **Observed regression removed.** In Africa, the count of reaches whose NetCDF node rows were split into multiple file blocks dropped from 536 in 0.0.5 to 0 in 0.0.6. Pierre-Olivier Malaterre's example reach 13341000591 now appears as one contiguous node block with node_order = 1..93.

0.0.5 (April 2026)

- **Promoted corrected bundle to a new version.** The corrected April 2 reissue is now published as 0.0.5 instead of reusing 0.0.4, so testers do not keep hitting stale downloads or cached copies under the same name. This 0.0.5 bundle supersedes all prior 0.0.4 beta uploads on Drive.
- **Release regressions from distributed 0.0.4 artifacts fixed.** The 0.0.5 bundle corrects the specific tester-reported regressions from the prior 0.0.4 uploads: reversed node dist_out relative to node_order, stale dn_node_id / up_node_id orientation on flow-corrected reaches, missing nodes layers in some GeoPackages, NULL dist_out_dijkstra at isolated ghost coastal outlets, and inconsistent single-node node-distance convention relative to the other node-level outlet distances.
- **Release artifacts renamed and resynced.** NetCDF, GeoPackage, Parquet, release notes, and SHA256 manifests now use 0.0.5 filenames consistently in the local beta folder and Google Drive beta folder.

0.0.4 (March 2026)

- **Node propagation to 11.1M nodes.** Five v17c columns (best_headwater, best_outlet, pathlen_hw, pathlen_out, subnetwork_id) were NULL on all nodes. Now propagated from parent reaches.
- **Dijkstra ghost outlet fix.** Ghost reaches (type=6) with out_degree=0 no longer report dist_out_dijkstra=0. All sinks are used as Dijkstra sources for full coverage, with outlet values following the v17b convention (dist_out_dijkstra = reach_length). Real outlet counts: NA=7, SA=1, EU=2, AF=1, AS=11, OC=1.
- **Bifurcation routing fix.** At multi-successor nodes, rch_id_dn_main now follows the mainstem chain unconditionally (was falling back to score-based ranking, which could disagree with is_mainstem). V023 (pathlen_out step consistency) violations: 2 → 0.
- **hydro_dist_hw computed.** Mainstem distance from headwater via rch_id_up_main chain walk (mirror of hydro_dist_out). Was stale from a prior pipeline run.
- **facc monotonicity fix (T003).** 419 reaches corrected via iterative downstream propagation. T003 violations: 392 → 0.
- **Routing weights retrained on effective_slope.** SWOT slope_obs_p50 (where reliable and n>=5) replaces MERIT DEM slope in routing score training. Slope share: 8% → 3%, width: 67% → 71%. CV accuracy unchanged (88.5%).
- **Node-level distance interpolation.** hydro_dist_out, hydro_dist_hw, and dist_out_dijkstra added to nodes table, interpolated by node position within reach (using v17b dist_out offset). pathlen_hw and pathlen_out changed from flat reach copies to per-node interpolated values.
- **hydro_dist_hw convention fix.** Reach-level values shifted from downstream-end reporting to upstream-end reporting, matching dist_out, hydro_dist_out, and dist_out_dijkstra. Headwater reaches now report 0 (was reach_length). Node-level values unchanged.
- **F006 junction conservation fix.** 2 remaining junction violations (OC 53130100215, AS 45311901585) resolved by setting downstream facc to sum of upstream facc. F006 violations: 2 → 0.

- **13 AS `main_side` reverted to v17b.** Reaches had `main_side` changed from 0 (main) to 1 (side) by an undetermined prior operation; 9 of 13 are linear reaches where side-channel classification is impossible.
- **Distance convention documented.** Variable reference now includes a convention table specifying endpoint reporting, zero-point, and ghost reach behavior for all distance variables, plus node-level interpolation formulas.
- **Variable reference updated.** 7 missing variables added, 8 type mismatches fixed, multi-dimensional array documentation corrected. (The NetCDF export itself uses the v17b `cl_ids [2, N]` format.)
- **Node dist_out reactive recalc fix.** `CALCULATE_DIST_OUT` operations now correctly recalculate node-level `dist_out` by sorting nodes via `node_order` (geometric position) instead of `node_id`. This fixes an issue where flow-corrected reaches had incorrect node distances after recalculation (e.g., downstream-most node getting downstream reach's `dist_out`).
- **April 2 artifact reissue.** The published April 1 `0.0.4` files still had stale orientation metadata on 639 flow-corrected reaches. The reissued NetCDF, GeoPackage, and Parquet bundles recompute `node_order`, `dn_node_id`, and `up_node_id` from node `dist_out`, restore `dist_out_dijkstra = reach_length` for isolated ghost coastal outlets, and align single-node `node.dist_out` with the same midpoint convention used by the other node-level outlet distances.
- **Ghost coastal outlet dist_out_dijkstra fix.** Isolated ghost coastal outlets (type=6 sinks with upstream neighbors but no path to real hydrologic outlets) now receive `dist_out_dijkstra = reach_length`, matching v17b `dist_out` behavior. Previously these 703 reaches in NA (similar counts in other regions) had NULL, but they should report the reach-level outlet distance to the ocean outlet point.
- **Exports regenerated (April 1 and 2, 2026).** The initial April 1 bundle captured the code fixes above. The April 2 reissue refreshed NetCDF, GeoPackage, and Parquet artifacts plus SHA256SUMS after repairing published `node_order` / boundary-node orientation metadata, ghost coastal outlet `dist_out_dijkstra`, and single-node node-distance conventions.

0.0.3 (March 2026)

- **Routing weights learned from human labels.** Replaced the handcrafted lexicographic 3-tuple `(effective_width, log_facc, pathlen)` with a weighted scalar score trained on 1,967 human-labeled junction decisions: '1.97*log1p(ew) + 0.23*log1p(facc) - 0.23*log1p(slope) + 0.23*log1p(pathlen)
  - 0.29*stream_order'. Two new signals vs prior releases: slope (negative = prefer lower gradient) and stream_order. All routing functions use the same score to prevent divergence. (Weights retrained in 0.0.4; see above.)
- **Caroline's reviewer fixes synced.** 127 C001 lakeflag fixes (NA) and 10 C004 type fixes (NA) from the Streamlit reviewer app.
- **NA PostgreSQL geometry fix.** 38,696 NA reaches had NULL geometry in PostgreSQL — v17b geometry overwrite via dblink silently failed. Rewrote to read from v17b GPKG files on disk with verification gates.
- Fixed `dn_node_id`, `up_node_id`, and `node_order` for 810 flow-corrected reaches where node ordering was stale (based on v17b `dist_out`). 639 reaches now have `dn_node_id != min(node_id)`, reflecting the inverted flow direction.
- Removed redundant `rch_id_up_1..4` / `rch_id_dn_1..4` vector variables from NetCDF export. Only the `[4, N]` matrices `rch_id_up` and `rch_id_dn` are exported, matching v17b format.
- Fixed `swot_orbits` NetCDF type from string back to int64 (matching v17b).
- Fixed 15 integer columns widened from int32 to int64 in NetCDF export (`n_nodes`, `lakeflag`, `n_rch_up`, `stream_order`, etc.). All shared variable types now match v17b exactly.
- Synced `rch_id_up_1..4` / `rch_id_dn_1..4` DB columns from `reach_topology` table (694 were stale after flow corrections).

0.0.2 (March 2026)

- Renamed `is_mainstem_edge` to `is_mainstem`
- Mainstem algorithm refactored: computed per `main_path_id` group (see Section 2.1)
- Fixed `n_rch_up`/`n_rch_down` stale counts at 148 flow-corrected reaches
- Recomputed `facc` at 807 flow-corrected reaches using topological propagation; resolves all F006 junction conservation violations and T003 monotonicity violations at these reaches
- OC reach 51111300061 incomplete split fully reverted to v17b state (434 orphan centerlines, 73 orphan nodes restored)

0.0.1 (March 2026)

- Initial v17c beta release
- Includes `node_order`, `dn_node_id`, `up_node_id` (node ordering within reaches)

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1. Overview

v17c **retains every v17b variable** (no columns removed) and adds new columns on top. v17b's static fields are preserved unchanged; the only changes to existing variables are the specific corrections noted below (`facc`, node `dist_out`, and `lakeflag`/`type`). The additions fall into three groups:

1. **Actual SWOT-derived observational data** (new). For the first time, SWORD carries measured SWOT water-surface elevation, width, and slope aggregated per reach and node from real overpasses — percentile summaries (`wse_obs_*`, `width_obs_*`, `slope_obs_*`), spread statistics, and observation counts (`n_obs`). These are new columns derived from SWOT observations; they do not modify the v17b static `wse`, `width`, or `slope` variables, which are retained as-is.
2. **Computed mainstem topology and routing** (new): mainstem identification, best-headwater/outlet routing, new distance metrics, and a globally unique `subnetwork_id`.
3. **One correction to an existing v17b variable**: flow accumulation (`facc`) rebuilt on every reach and node from MERIT-Basins drainage areas matched to the SWORD network, with the area partitioned among channels at splits. Two companion columns are new: `facc_total`, the whole-river area, and `facc_flag`, a per-reach label.

Alongside these, v17c ships data-quality fixes to v17b-inherited fields (node geolocation and ordering repairs, lakeflag/type reconciliation). No reaches, nodes, or centerlines were added or removed. v17c contains the same 248,673 reaches, 11.1M nodes, and 66.9M centerline points as v17b across all six regions (NA, SA, EU, AF, AS, OC).

Each region is distributed as a single NetCDF4 file (`{region}_sword_v17c.nc`). The group structure matches v17b (centerlines, nodes, reaches), and the `area_fits` and `discharge_models` subgroups under reaches pass through from v17b unchanged. Reach and centerline arrays match v17b canonical row ordering. Node arrays are grouped contiguously by `reach_id` and ordered within each reach by `node_order` (downstream to upstream).

Reach coordinate columns (`x`, `y`, `x_min`, `x_max`, `y_min`, `y_max`) match v17b values across all formats (NetCDF, DuckDB, PostgreSQL). Node coordinate columns (`x`, `y`) also match v17b after the v17c continuity revert.

All new variables use a fill value of -9999 where no observation or computation produced a value.

For a complete variable catalog, see v17c_variable_reference.md.

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2. New Variables

2.1 Mainstem Topology (reaches group)

`is_mainstem` is computed per `main_path_id` group: each group (a mainstem path plus its tributary branches) gets one canonical chain, identified by a greedy walk from the group's shared `best_headwater`. At each junction the algorithm selects the upstream branch with the highest weighted routing score: `2.02*log1p(ew) + 0.17*log1p(facc) - 0.08*log1p(slope) + 0.35*log1p(pathlen) + 0.23*stream_order`. These weights were learned from 1,967 human-labeled junction decisions via logistic regression on pairwise log1p-difference features, using SWOT slope where reliable (else MERIT DEM). The negative slope weight captures the geomorphic pattern that mainstem channels have lower gradients than tributaries. Mainstem reaches within each group are then assigned `rch_id_up_main` / `rch_id_dn_main` from the chain; non-mainstem reaches use the same weighted score. Ghost reaches (type=6) are excluded from mainstem but still participate in routing topology. ~10% of mainstem reaches have no mainstem neighbor at `main_path_id` group boundaries — this is expected by design.

Variable	Type	Units	Description
`dist_out_dijkstra`	float64	meters	Dijkstra shortest-path outlet distance reported at the reach upstream endpoint (outlet = `reach_length`; values retained for ghost reaches)

Variable	Type	Units	Description
hydro_dist_out	float64	meters	Mainstem outlet distance reported at the reach upstream endpoint via rch_id_dn_main chain (outlet = reach_length)
hydro_dist_hw	float64	meters	Mainstem headwater distance reported at the reach upstream endpoint via rch_id_up_main chain (headwater = 0)
rch_id_up_main	int64	—	Main upstream neighbor reach_id (mainstem-preferred)
rch_id_dn_main	int64	—	Main downstream neighbor reach_id (mainstem-preferred)
best_headwater	int64	—	Routing-score-prioritized headwater reach_id for the network component
best_outlet	int64	—	Routing-score-prioritized outlet reach_id for the network component
pathlen_hw	float64	meters	Cumulative path length from best_headwater
pathlen_out	float64	meters	Cumulative path length to best_outlet
is_mainstem	int32	—	1 if reach is on a mainstem path, 0 otherwise
main_path_id	int64	—	Unique identifier for each mainstem path group
subnetwork_id	int32	—	Connected component ID (Pfafstetter-offset, globally unique; see Section 4)
dn_node_id	int64	—	Node ID at the downstream end of the reach (lowest dist_out)
up_node_id	int64	—	Node ID at the upstream end of the reach (highest dist_out)

Eight of these variables also appear at node level. Six are interpolated by node position within the reach: dist_out, hydro_dist_out, hydro_dist_hw, dist_out_dijkstra, pathlen_hw, and pathlen_out. Three are flat copies from the parent reach: subnetwork_id, best_headwater, and best_outlet. Historical flow-correction topology flips were fully reverted in 0.0.9, so the current v17c database does not retain a flow-corrected reach set requiring reversed node_id order.

All six interpolated distance columns use midpoint offsets: offset = cumsum(node_length) - 0.5 * node_length. dist_out, hydro_dist_out, dist_out_dijkstra, and pathlen_hw use reach_value - reach_length + offset; hydro_dist_hw and pathlen_out use reach_value + reach_length - offset. This places each node at the geometric center of its node_length segment. On a single-path network (no junctions), node-level dist_out, hydro_dist_out, and dist_out_dijkstra are exactly equal.

node_order is a node-level variable (not in the reaches table): 1-based position within a reach, ordered by dist_out ascending (1 = downstream end, n = upstream end).

Distance convention note. These are endpoint-reported reach scalars, not traversal-origin claims. dist_out, hydro_dist_out, and dist_out_dijkstra are outlet-distance values reported at the reach upstream endpoint and assign reach_length at the outlet. hydro_dist_hw is also reported at the reach upstream endpoint, but measures distance from best_headwater and assigns 0 at the headwater. See the variable reference for the full convention table.

2.2 SWOT Observation Statistics

These are v17c's new SWOT-derived observational columns: water-surface elevation, width, and slope **measured by SWOT** and aggregated per reach and node across all qualifying overpasses, as percentile summaries with spread statistics and observation counts. They are distinct from — and do not modify — the v17b static wse, width, and slope

variables, which are retained unchanged. All percentile, range, and MAD variables share the units of the underlying measurement.

SWOT slope derivation. Reach `slope_obs_*` values are computed from pass-level linear regressions of RiverSP node water-surface elevation (`wse_sm`) against node `dist_out`, then aggregated to reach-level percentiles across passes. `slope_obs_p50` is populated on 173,732 reaches (the remainder lack sufficient SWOT slope observations); of these, 9,988 have a negative median slope, flagged via `slope_obs_quality` / `slope_obs_q`.

Reaches and nodes:

Variable	Type	Units	Description
`wse_obs_p10`–`wse_obs_p90`	float64	meters	WSE percentiles (10th through 90th, in steps of 10)
`wse_obs_range`	float64	meters	WSE observation range (p90 - p10)
`wse_obs_mad`	float64	meters	WSE median absolute deviation
`width_obs_p10`–`width_obs_p90`	float64	meters	Width percentiles
`width_obs_range`	float64	meters	Width observation range
`width_obs_mad`	float64	meters	Width median absolute deviation
`n_obs`	int32	—	Total SWOT observation count

Reaches only:

Variable	Type	Units	Description
`slope_obs_p10`–`slope_obs_p90`	float64	m/m	Slope percentiles
`slope_obs_range`	float64	m/m	Slope observation range
`slope_obs_mad`	float64	m/m	Slope median absolute deviation
`slope_obs_adj`	float64	m/m	Adjusted slope
`slope_obs_slopeF`	float64	—	Slope F-statistic
`slope_obs_reliable`	int32	—	0 = unreliable, 1 = reliable
`slope_obs_quality`	int32	—	Integer quality category (0–8; see Section 3)
`slope_obs_n`	int32	—	Number of RiverSP node observations used in pass-level slope fits
`slope_obs_n_passes`	int32	—	Number of SWOT passes used
`slope_obs_q`	int32	—	Bitfield quality flag (see Section 3)

2.3 Flow Accumulation

v17b took `facc` from MERIT Hydro's D8 flow accumulation raster, which gives every channel of a braided or delta reach the whole river's area and mislabels reaches where the raster and the vector network disagree. v17c replaces every `facc` value. SWORD reaches are matched to the MERIT-Basins river network and take its drainage areas; reaches with no usable match are interpolated along the channel, derived from their inflows (lakes), or filled from neighbours. At every reach with more than one downstream channel, the area is partitioned among the channels in proportion to their widths, and each side channel's share is debited from the main channel, so the shares at all 2,893 splits add up to the parent's area. Width-based shares are a convention: they are not measured discharge fractions.

Because the values come from a different source, `facc` differs from v17b on 248,667 of the 248,673 reaches (relative tolerance 1e-6): raised on 132,337 and lowered on 116,330. Most changes are small (regional medians +4% to +5% for raises and 6% to 12% for decreases); the large ones are at braided and delta channels, where v17b gave each channel the whole river's area, and at reaches where the D8 raster had been matched to the wrong river.

Two drainage-area numbers are carried. For a 100 km^2 river that splits into two channels with no tributary between them, `facc` is 70 and 30 on the two arms and `facc_total` stays 100 on both; when the arms rejoin, the shared area is counted once.

Variable	Type	Group	Description
facc	float64	reaches, nodes	Drainage area of this channel (km^2). The reach value is at its downstream end; node values are interpolated along the reach.
facc_total	float64	reaches, nodes	Whole-river drainage area at this point, all channels combined (km^2). Equals facc away from splits. Use it to compare with gauges and basins.
facc_flag	string	reaches, nodes	One label per reach, copied to its nodes: ok, suspect, same_river, braid_share, delta_arm, filled. See §3.
facc_quality	int32	reaches, nodes	Source method of the facc value, coded 3001-3008 (string rederived_v3:<source> in the other formats). See §3.

Checks on the shipped values. Along single channels facc never decreases downstream. In the 18,241-junction test (junctions with two or more inflows, none of which itself splits), every exit is at least its largest inflow; the 50 connections across which the model transfers no channel area lie outside that test, and their 23 receiving reaches are flagged suspect (§4). The partition closes at all 2,893 splits. facc never exceeds facc_total, and 1,851 reaches sit at the 1 km^2 floor. At 1,428 junctions the outgoing facc is below the sum of its inflows; every one of them is flagged (§4). An ok flag does not mean the reach is unsplit: 7,490 ok reaches have facc below facc_total, because the main channel below a split is debited by the side channels' shares and is not itself flagged.

Agreement with reference drainage areas, scored on facc_total at every reach with a reference:

Reference	Within 20%	Median absolute error	v17b within 20%
HydroBASINS outlets (6,262)	5,310 (84.8%)	0.96%	72.7%
SVS gauges (2,297)	2,119 (92.3%)	1.62%	77.6%
USGS gauges (101)	98 (97.0%)	1.80%	76.2%

2.4 Other New or Updated Variables

dl_grod_id integrates a newly added obstruction dataset, DL-GROD (Deep Learning Global River Obstruction Database; He et al. 2025), populated on 26,120 reaches.

Variable	Type	Group	Description
type	int32	reaches	Reach classification (1=river, 3=lake_on_river, 4=dam, 5=unreliable, 6=ghost). Not present in v17b NetCDF; added in v17c so NetCDF users can filter by reach type without needing the database.
dl_grod_id	int64	reaches	DL-GROD (Deep Learning Global River Obstruction Database; He et al. 2025) dam/obstruction ID; populated on 26,120 reaches
edit_flag	string	reaches	Comma-delimited edit provenance tags (e.g., harp_lake,clf_reconcile). Also contains v17b numeric codes and the literal string NaN (v17b's no-edit placeholder); see the variable reference for the full value list

3. Flag Encoding Reference

facc_flag

String variable on reaches and nodes; a node carries its reach's label. Only the highest-priority label is stored, in the order listed.

Value	Reaches	Meaning
`suspect`	6,282	A check failed or a known case is unresolved: outgoing `facc` below the sum of inflows, a width/area screen, no valid width for the check, an unresolved MERIT placement or direction question.
`same_river`	1,328	Inflows at this junction may share drainage area, so summing them can count area twice. Not a claim that each channel carries the whole river.
`delta_arm`	8,718	Contains an unvalidated distributary share, or the estimate was limited by the model. Not a geographic delta label.
`braid_share`	12,562	Contains a width-based channel share that has not been independently measured.
`filled`	5,534	Filled from neighbouring reaches, a headwater prior, or a replacement for a rejected MERIT match. The weakest values.
`ok`	214,249	No check or processing category was triggered. Not proof of accuracy.

facc_quality

Source method of the `facc` value. NetCDF stores the code; GeoPackage, GeoParquet and DuckDB store the string. It is not an accuracy grade; use `facc_flag` for warnings.

Code	String	Reaches	Meaning
3001	`rederived_v3:anchor`	189,450	MERIT-Basins reach matched to this reach
3002	`rederived_v3:anchor_proximity`	4,377	MERIT-Basins reach paired by proximity
3003	`rederived_v3:anchor_aligned`	152	MERIT-Basins reach matched by junction alignment
3004	`rederived_v3:interpolated`	7,246	Interpolated along the channel between matched reaches
3005	`rederived_v3:lake_derived`	28,593	Lake reach derived from its inflows
3006	`rederived_v3:partitioned_arm`	9,066	Side channel or distributary carrying a width-based share
3007	`rederived_v3:fallback_fill`	8,302	Carried from neighbouring reaches
3008	`rederived_v3:fallback_prior`	1,487	Headwater prior

CF attributes: `flag_values = [3001, ..., 3008]`, `flag_meanings` lists the strings with `:` replaced by `_`.

slope_obs_quality

Value	Meaning
0	reliable
1	small_negative
2	moderate_negative
3	large_negative
4	negative
5	below_ref_uncertainty
6	high_uncertainty
7	noise_high_nobs
8	flat_water_noise

CF attributes: `flag_values = [0,1,2,3,4,5,6,7,8]`, `flag_meanings = "reliable small_negative moderate_negative large_negative negative below_ref_uncertainty high_uncertainty noise_high_nobs flat_water_noise"`.

The working database also carries a `below_noise` category (427 reaches, slope below the SWOT noise floor) that is not among codes 0-8; in this release those reaches export with the `slope_obs_quality` fill value (-9999). They still carry a `slope_obs_p50` value, so filter on `slope_obs_p50 != -9999` rather than on `slope_obs_quality` alone when selecting reaches with a computed slope.

slope_obs_reliable

Value	Meaning
0	Unreliable
1	Reliable
-9999 (fill)	Not computed (no SWOT slope observations)

slope_obs_q (bitfield)

Bit	Value	Meaning
1	1	Negative slope
2	2	Low number of passes
3	4	High variance
4	8	Extreme value
5	16	Clipped

Flags combine by addition. A value of 0 indicates no quality issues. Example: 5 = negative slope (1) + high variance (4).

is_mainstem

Value	Meaning
0	Not on mainstem
1	On mainstem path

4. Known Limitations

- **SWOT observation coverage:** SWOT statistics are fill_value (-9999) for reaches and nodes lacking SWOT data.

- **facc junction shortfalls:** at 1,428 junctions the outgoing `facc` is below the sum of its inflows (0.0.14: 2,660). Of these, 76 are new and 140 grew by more than 1 km^2 when the split partition was made conservative. Some inflow sums count shared drainage twice; others are junctions where MERIT-Basins places the confluence somewhere other than SWORD does. All 1,428 are flagged `suspect` or `same_river`.
- **facc width shares are a convention:** at splits the area is divided by channel width, not by measured discharge. Reaches carrying such a share are `braid_share` or `delta_arm` (21,280 reaches).
- **facc fills:** 5,534 reaches (`filled`) have no usable MERIT-Basins match and take values from their neighbours or a headwater prior.
- **facc open cases:** 29 reaches with an unresolved MERIT placement question, two weak outlets, and the AS reach pair 43308000201 and 43309000191, whose stored routing and node direction labels disagree, are all flagged `suspect`. The model assigns zero channel area across 50 connections; the 23 receiving reaches are flagged `suspect`.
- **Lake sandwich corrections:** 1,252 reaches were reclassified to `lakeflag = 1` where a narrow, shorter-than-neighbor reach sat between lake reaches. The later lakeflag/type reconciliation (0.0.10) rewrote many `edit_flag` tags, so 483 reaches carry a `lake_sandwich` tag in the v17c database. ~1,755 similar cases remain (narrow connecting channels, chains).
- **HarP lake corrections:** 7,425 reaches were reclassified from `lakeflag = 0` (river) to `lakeflag = 1` (lake) based on HarP v1.1 (Hydrography and River Planform) lake classification data, with child node lakeflag updated to match (node lakeflag matches the parent reach on all 11,112,454 nodes as of 0.0.11). The later lakeflag/type reconciliation (0.0.10) folded many of these into combined tags, so 3,981 reaches carry a `harp_lake` tag in the v17c database; node `edit_flag` is not tagged. Tags are comma-delimited when multiple apply.
- **Neighbor-array fill convention (vs v17b):** In the NetCDF `rch_id_up` and `rch_id_dn [4, N]` arrays, empty neighbor slots use the fill value `-9999`, whereas v17b used `0`. The neighbor relationships themselves are identical to v17b; only the empty-slot sentinel differs. Code that diffs the raw arrays against v17b, or that treats `0` as "no neighbor," should account for this.
- **Swapped neighbor vectors on two reaches, corrected in 0.0.15:** in the July and September 2026 GeoPackage, GeoParquet and DuckDB files, reaches 45220300256 (AS) and 71382000696 (NA) carry their single downstream neighbor in `rch_id_up_1` with `rch_id_dn_1..4` = 0. The NetCDF `rch_id_up`/`rch_id_dn` arrays were correct in every version.
- **area_fits and discharge_models:** Direct copies from v17b. Not recomputed against v17c facc or SWOT values.
- **`subnetwork_id` vs `network`:** `subnetwork_id` uses Pfafstetter- offset enumeration (globally unique). v17b `network` uses per-region 1-based IDs. Different component counts (v17c finds more via weakly connected components; 19 subnetworks span multiple v17b networks). `network` is retained unchanged from v17b.
- **Flow correction fully reverted:** experimental flow-direction corrections (810 reaches at peak, including 389 with ambiguous oscillating WSE slope signals) were fully reverted to v17b topology in 0.0.9 after a scoring tautology was found. v17c topology is identical to v17b; `v17c_flow_corrections` is empty.
- **main_path_id consistency:** 19 `(best_headwater, best_outlet)` tuples map to more than one `main_path_id` (V015 lint check), affecting 230 reaches. The related continuity checks (V013, V014) and `best_headwater` validity (V007) report zero violations.
- **River naming:** 51.2% of reaches are unnamed (NODATA), ranging from 26% (AF) to 69% (OC). 2.6% of mainstem 1:1 links have local name discontinuities (name changes between adjacent reaches with no junction).
- **Width fill values (A003):** ~1,266 reaches have `width=0` (unmeasured) or `width=-1` (GRWL lake fill). These are v17b fill values, not data errors. Present in both v17b and v17c unchanged. The A003 lint check is downgraded to WARNING for this reason.
- **Node geolocation corrections deferred:** The 0.0.8 and 0.0.10 rederived-node coordinate edits were reverted in v17c to preserve SWOT D0-D2 time-series continuity. Some node sequence/geolocation anomalies inherited from v17b therefore remain. Treat full geolocation repair as a v18 or separately approved release-envelope change.

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5. Quality Audits

Validation checks performed on the v17c data:

Audit	Finding
Flow accumulation (facc)	Every reach and node rebuilt from MERIT-Basins. 0 downstream decreases along single channels; 0 exits below their largest inflow in the 18,241-junction test; the split partition closes at all 2,893 splits; `facc <= facc_total` everywhere. 1,428 junction shortfalls remain, all flagged. The four facc fields in every shipped format match the database on all 248,673 reaches and 11,112,454 nodes; in the Shapefiles the two areas are stored with 8 decimals (DBF `numeric(19,8)`), so they differ from the database by at most 5e-9 km^2.
SWOT observation data (`wse_obs_*`, `width_obs_*`, `slope_obs_*`)	New SWOT-derived columns aggregated from real overpasses; they do not modify the v17b static `wse`/`width`/`slope`. `slope_obs_p50` populated on 173,732 reaches (9,988 negative, flagged via `slope_obs_quality`); derived from pass-level node-WSE regressions (see §2.2).
Geometry	DuckDB geometries (rebuilt from NetCDF) lack endpoint overlap vertices present in v17b (210,533 reaches affected: 173K +1 point, 37K +2 points). `reach_length` unchanged. Reach coordinate columns (`x`, `y`, `x_min`, `x_max`, `y_min`, `y_max`) copied from v17b to ensure consistency across all formats.
Node coordinate continuity	v17c restores v17b node `x`/`y`, `node_length`, `cl_id_min`, and `cl_id_max` for the 344 previously rederived reaches plus OC reach 51111300061 split-revert residue. Global node coordinate diff vs v17b NetCDF: 0.
n_nodes / reach_length	Internally consistent. Zero N008/G002/G003 violations.
path_freq gaps	v17b had 4,952 connected non-ghost reaches with invalid path_freq (0 or -9999). Resolved in v17c; remaining nodata values are correctly attributed to ghost reaches (type=6).
subnetwork_id	3,027 components across 248,673 reaches verified. Pfafstetter banding correct. Zero cross-region collisions. 19 subnetworks (0.6%) span multiple v17b networks (expected).
Topology integrity	T001 (dist_out_dijkstra monotonicity), T012 (referential integrity), T013 (self-reference), T014 (bidirectional): all pass. T005/T007: zero non-reciprocal edges (151 from incomplete flow correction revert resolved in beta 0.0.1). Historical flow-correction topology flips were fully reverted in 0.0.9; `v17c_flow_corrections` is empty in the current database. Node-level `dist_out` is recomputed for all reaches using the midpoint interpolation convention.
n_rch_up/n_rch_down	148 scalar count mismatches corrected (flow corrections flipped reach_topology but did not recalculate counts). Zero mismatches across all 248,673 reaches.
OC reach split revert	Incomplete `break_reaches()` split of OC reach 51111300061 (434 orphan centerlines, 73 orphan nodes) fully reverted to v17b state.
River name formatting	291 formatting issues corrected (separators, whitespace). Automated checks now enforce ";" separator and alphabetical ordering.

Audit	Finding
Flow direction	Experimental topology flips were ultimately reverted. The 1,112-flip experiment caused ~30K disconnected reaches and was rolled back; the later retained flow-correction family was also fully reverted in 0.0.9 after the scoring tautology was found. Current v17c does not retain topology that differs from v17b because of this flow-correction pipeline.
HarP lake corrections	7,425 reaches reclassified lakeflag 0 to 1 from HarP v1.1 data, with node lakeflag propagated from parent reaches. After the 0.0.10 lakeflag/type reconciliation rewrote tags, 3,981 reaches carry a `harp_lake` tag in v17c.
lakeflag/type consistency	~6,200 inconsistent reaches reconciled (0.0.10) via 1,015 manual reviews, a gradient-boosted classifier (82% precision, applied only at high confidence), and HarP v1.1 corrections. All 248,673 reaches are consistent under the two primary rules (no lakeflag=1 with type=1, no lakeflag=0 with type=3); some rarer lakeflag/type edge combinations (e.g. lakeflag=3 tidal with type=1) remain and are expected. `type` is authoritative and diverges from the reach ID last digit on 2,648 reaches (1.1%) in v17c due to in-place corrections.

For POM (Pierre-Olivier Malaterre) validation results, see pom_validation_report.md.

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6. File Formats

v17c is distributed as six packages, five formats plus whole-planet global files. The NetCDF files are the canonical release artifact (full group structure including centerlines and v17b subgroups); the other formats carry reaches and nodes with geometry.

- **NetCDF4:** `{region}_sword_v17c.nc`, one file per region, where region is `na`, `sa`, `eu`, `af`, `as`, `oc`
  - Groups: `centerlines`, `nodes`, `reaches` (plus `reaches/area_fits` and `reaches/discharge_models` subgroups from v17b)
  - Ordering: reach and centerline arrays match v17b canonical ordering; node arrays are reach-contiguous and sorted by `node_order`
  - Fill value: -9999 for all numeric variables (int32, int64, float64)
- **GeoPackage:** `sword_{REGION}_v17c.gpkg` per region (reaches and nodes layers)
- **Shapefile:** `{region}_sword_{reaches,nodes}_hb{XX}_v17c.shp`, split by HydroBASINS Pfafstetter level-2 basin within each region (v17b convention; required by the shapefile 2 GB size limit). Shapefile DBF format truncates attribute names to 10 characters, so fields use abbreviated names; the mapping table `shapefile_field_name_mapping.csv` ships alongside the shapefiles. The NetCDF/GeoPackage/GeoParquet names are authoritative.
- **GeoParquet:** `sword_{REGION}_v17c_{reaches,nodes}.parquet` per region
- **DuckDB:** `sword_{REGION}_v17c.duckdb` per region, with `reaches` and `nodes` tables (geometry stored as GEOMETRY type; written with DuckDB 1.3 — open with DuckDB >= 1.3 and the spatial extension)
- **Global files:** in addition to the per-region files, whole-planet merged tables are provided as `sword_global_v17c_{reaches,no` and `sword_global_v17c_{reaches,nodes}.duckdb` (all six regions combined; each table carries a `region` column).
- **Checksums:** `SHA256SUMS.txt` lists the six ZIPs as uploaded; `SHA256SUMS_files.txt` lists every file inside them, for checking after unzipping.
- **ID translation (separate archive on the record):** `SWORD_v17b_to_v16_Translation.zip` holds the official reach and node ID translation tables between v17b and v16 for all six regions. v17c keeps v17b IDs, so the tables apply to v17c unchanged.

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7. Methodology Documentation

Document	Description
pom_requests_summary.md	POM validation check tracker (19 checks, production results)
pom_validation_report.md	POM validation production results
v17c_variable_reference.md	Complete variable catalog for NetCDF export
SWORD_v17b_Technical_Documentation.md	v17b baseline reference